SECOND NOTICE — Part One

A screenplay
Second Notice
Part One

FADE IN:

EXT. LOGGING ROAD - NIGHT

Dense Alaskan forest, black on black. A single pair of headlights crawl along a gravel switchback.

A LOG TRUCK, overloaded, groans under its own weight.

INT. LOG TRUCK - CONTINUOUS

JIM (25, lean, patchy beard, a knit cap he never takes off) drives with one hand, eating sunflower seeds with the other. Shells pile in the cupholder.

DOG (34, broad, quiet, hands scarred across the knuckles) rides shotgun. Stares out the window like he's counting trees.

JIM
You ever think about how we're basically just moving really expensive firewood around all night?

Dog says nothing.

JIM (CONT'D)
That's the whole job. Felt that way to you? Ever?

DOG
Non.

JIM
"Non." You're French now?

DOG
Watch the road.

Somewhere out in the dark treeline --

KNOCK.

Jim's head snaps toward the sound. Dog doesn't move, but his jaw tightens.

JIM
...The hell was that.

DOG
(quiet)
Nothing.

A beat. Then --

KNOCK. KNOCK.

Dog sits up straight now, scanning the treeline hard.

JIM
That ain't nothing.

DOG
(low, urgent)
Pull over.

JIM
We got a schedule, man, Walt's gonna --

DOG
PULL OVER.

Jim pulls over. Cuts the engine. Silence floods in.

JIM
(trying to joke through it)
Scale of one to ten, how worried should I be right now.

DOG
(dead serious)
Four.

JIM
Four's not that bad.

DOG
Four's bad enough.

Dog opens his door.

EXT. LOGGING ROAD - CONTINUOUS

Dog steps out, flashlight up, scanning the treeline. Jim follows, seeds still in hand, trying to look braver than he feels.

JIM
What's two knocks mean? Is there a glossary? 'Cause one knock I got, that's like a "hello," but two --

DOG
Two means we're already late.

JIM
Late for what.

Dog doesn't answer. He's listening.

A THIRD KNOCK -- closer. Much closer. Right behind the truck.

Jim and Dog turn as one.

Nothing there. Just dark.

Then the GROUND SHUDDERS. Something massive moves through the treeline, unseen, shaking needles loose from the canopy.

The truck's load of logs SHIFTS violently --

DOG

MOVE --
He shoves Jim clear as the entire load tips, logs crashing down across the cab in an avalanche of timber and sound. The truck folds like a beer can.

Silence after. Steam hisses from the crushed engine block.

Jim, on the ground, staring at the wreck.

JIM
(small voice)
...Four was generous.

CUT TO:

INT. TRAPPER'S CABIN - NIGHT (INSERT - FLASHBACK, 1966)

Grainy, high-contrast. A YOUNG DOG (25) crouches in the doorway of this same cabin, rifle shaking in his hands. We don't see what he's aiming at -- just his face, pure terror.

A GUNSHOT.

Something roars -- pained, massive, ancient.

BACK TO SCENE

EXT. LOGGING ROAD - NIGHT

Dog, present day, staring at the wreck, breathing hard. The flashback lives behind his eyes for just a second too long.

JIM
You good?

DOG
(snapping back)
We walk from here.

JIM
Walk WHERE. It's the middle of the night and something just ate our truck.

DOG
There's a crossing. Four miles. Ford across the river. Radio works from the ranger box on the other side.

JIM
Four miles through THAT.
(points into the trees)
What even hit us?

Dog starts walking. Doesn't answer.

JIM (CONT'D)
(following, to himself)
Cool. Cool cool cool. Love that for us.

EXT. FOREST TRAIL - NIGHT - LATER

SUPER: 12:14 AM

Jim and Dog move single file, flashlights cutting thin lines through fog. Jim keeps glancing at the trees.

JIM
So back there -- the knocks. You knew what that was before it hit us.

DOG
Didn't know it'd hit us.

JIM
But you knew SOMETHING.

Dog keeps walking.

JIM (CONT'D)
Dog. Come on. You've been doing this route longer than me. You flinched before anything even happened.

DOG
(finally)
There's a toll. Been one longer than either of us worked here.

JIM
A toll. Like a bridge toll.

DOG
Like a bridge toll that eats trucks if you don't pay it.

JIM
(trying to laugh)
Okay, so who do we make the check out to --

DOG
(sharp)
I'm serious, Jim.

Jim stops laughing. Dog rarely raises his voice.

JIM
...Okay. Who pays it. Walt?

A long pause. Too long.

DOG
I do.

JIM
You pay it.

DOG
Every June. Have for nine years.

JIM
(processing)
That's... that's not in the job description, man.

DOG
No. It's not.

Dog walks faster. Jim has to jog to keep up.

JIM
Did I -- wait. Did something happen with THIS year's --

Dog says nothing. That's answer enough.

JIM (CONT'D)
(quiet, sick realization)
I used the toll money. In June. I was short for the truck payment, I figured --
(beat)
I figured it was just, like, Walt's beer fund or something, I didn't --

DOG
(flat)
You didn't pay it.

JIM
I paid HALF. Last year I paid half, nothing bad happened --

DOG
Last year wasn't nothing. Last year was a warning.

Dog stops walking. Turns to face him fully for the first time.

DOG (CONT'D)
This is the second notice.

Off Jim's face -- the real fear setting in --

CUT TO:

EXT. FOREST TRAIL - NIGHT - LATER

SUPER: 12:36 AM

They walk in silence now. Fog thickens. Jim's flashlight flickers.

JIM
(trying to fill silence)
Scale of one to ten.

DOG
Six.

JIM
Six?! It was FOUR twenty minutes ago!

DOG
Twenty minutes ago you hadn't told me you stole the toll.

They keep walking. Somewhere distant -- a KNOCK. Single. Both of them freeze.

JIM
(whispering)
One knock's a hello, right? You said hello --

DOG
(whispering back)
Said hello's one knock. Didn't say who's saying it.

They move again, faster now, flashlights jittering across the trees.

EXT. FOREST TRAIL - BOG - NIGHT

SUPER: 1:20 AM

The trail disappears into standing black water between dead, bone-white trees. A rope line -- old, half-rotted -- is strung between trunks, marking a path through the bog.

JIM
Please tell me that's not the only way across.

DOG
It's not the only way. It's the way that doesn't kill you.

They start across, following the rope hand over hand. The water is utterly still. Too still.

Halfway across, Jim's flashlight catches something under the surface -- a shape, long and pale, gone before he can process it.

JIM
Did you --

DOG
Don't look at the water. Look at the rope.

JIM
I saw something --

DOG
(hard)
LOOK AT THE ROPE, JIM.

Jim fixes his eyes forward. Keeps moving. His hand finds the rope, white-knuckled.

Behind them, the water doesn't ripple -- but something tracks their movement beneath it, a wake with no source.

They reach the far side. Jim collapses onto solid ground, breathing hard.

JIM
What was that.

DOG
Don't know. Don't ask it questions either. Starts thinking you're interested.

JIM
(half-laughing, panicked)
I'm not INTERESTED, I'm TERRIFIED, there's a difference --

Dog's already walking. Jim scrambles up to follow.

EXT. FOREST TRAIL - NIGHT - LATER

SUPER: 2:15 AM

The trail narrows. Trees close in overhead, blotting out what little moon there was.

JIM
Nine years, Dog.

DOG
(not stopping)
Don't.

JIM
I'm not trying to -- I just -- why didn't you ever tell anybody. Tell WALT. Tell somebody who could help carry that.

DOG
(turning, sudden, raw)
Because I'm the one who shot it.

Silence. Jim stares at him.

JIM
...What?

DOG
Nineteen sixty-six. I was twenty-five. Thought it was a bear in the trap line. Wasn't a bear.

JIM
You shot --
(gesturing vaguely at the forest)
-- THAT?

DOG
Grazed it. Forehead. It's got the scar to prove it, if you ever get close enough to see, which I'm praying to God you don't.

JIM
And the toll's -- what, an apology? For forty years?

DOG
(quiet)
Some debts don't get paid off. They get paid DOWN. Every year. Forever, maybe. I don't know. Nobody tells you the terms. You just find out when you miss a payment.

He starts walking again. Jim, shaken, follows.

EXT. TRAPPER'S CABIN - NIGHT

SUPER: 2:40 AM

A sagging, moss-covered cabin emerges from the fog -- the same cabin from the 1966 flashback, decades older now.

JIM
Please tell me this has a radio.

DOG
It's got shelter. Storm's coming in behind us. We wait it out, then we cross the ford at first light.

Dog pushes the door open. It groans.

INT. TRAPPER'S CABIN - NIGHT - CONTINUOUS

Dust. A single busted window lets in gray moonlight. Jim sweeps his flashlight across the room --

-- and stops on the walls.

Every surface is carved. Names. Numbers. Hash marks stacked in columns like a ledger no one asked for.

JIM
(flashlight scanning, can't help himself)
Hollis... nineteen thirty-one.
(beat, moving the light)
Pruitt -- Jesus, fifty-nine to seventy-three. That's not a toll, that's a mortgage --

He keeps moving down the wall, narrating out of nerves more than curiosity -- the way he fills silence when he's scared.

JIM (CONT'D)
Looks like everybody who ever dropped a saw in this forest owes somebody something --

He stops.

Dead center of the wall -- a single carved line, deeper than the rest, like it was cut in anger:

Jim's flashlight holds on it. He doesn't say anything.

He turns to Dog, who hasn't moved from the doorway. Who clearly already knew it was there.

JIM (CONT'D)
(quiet, no joke left in it)
...Oh.

DOG
(not looking at the wall)
Non.

JIM
I didn't ask anything.

DOG
You were gonna.

Dog steps past him, deeper into the cabin, like the wall doesn't exist. Jim lowers the flashlight. Doesn't push it. Not yet.

He sits against the wall opposite the carvings, pulls his knees up. Tries, for once, to just be quiet.

It doesn't last.

JIM
Can I ask you something that's not about the wall.

DOG
(sitting, wary)
Depends.

JIM
If it doesn't give something back for free -- the forest, the toll, whatever this is -- what DOES it take? Like, in the worst case. What's the actual price.

Dog looks at him for a long moment. This is the first time he actually considers answering fully.

DOG
It don't give nothing back for free. You want breath, you trade something that uses it.

JIM
Cryptic. Cool. Love a good riddle at --
(checks nothing, has no watch)
-- whatever time it is.

DOG
2:40.

JIM
2:40. Cool.

Jim pulls his cap down over his eyes, trying to rest. Dog stays upright, alert, watching the door.

Outside, faint and far off -- a single KNOCK. Neither of them reacts this time. They're past reacting to one.

FADE OUT.

END OF PART ONE.